Government of Canada / Gouvernement du Canada

Smishing: Protect yourself from SMS attacks (ITSAP.00.103)

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Alternate format: Smishing: Protect yourself from SMS attacks - ITSAP.00.103 (PDF, 828 KB)

Smishing is a type of phishing scam. Threat actors use social engineering to send fraudulent text messages (SMS (short message service)) to trick victims into revealing sensitive information, such as login credentials or banking details. The text messages use language that creates a sense of urgency in an attempt to force the recipient to act fast. Smishing messages may link to malware or fake websites, allowing threat actors to steal your data, money or identity.

This publication was written in collaboration with the Royal Canadian Mounted Police to raise awareness on the identification, reporting and mitigation of smishing scams.

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- Tips for spotting a smishing message
- Protect yourself from smishing

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How threat actors leverage smishing

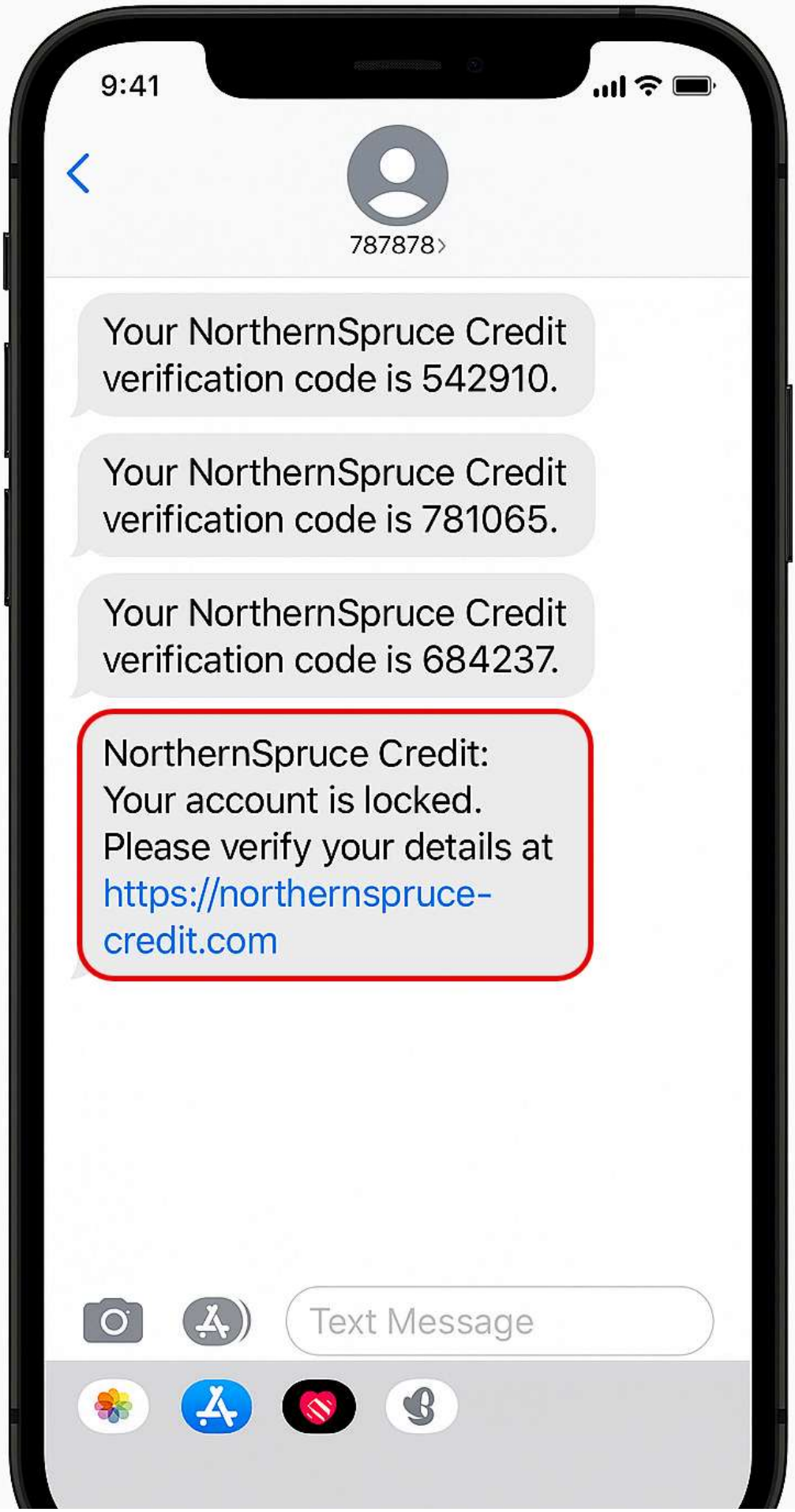
Modern smishing techniques enable threat actors to spoof the sender's phone number, making the message appear to come directly from a well known organization you trust. For example, if threat actors spoof your bank's legitimate short code, the fraudulent messages will appear in the same chat thread as any legitimate communications you may have had with your bank in the past. This continuation of the conversation makes it very difficult to distinguish fraudulent messages from valid messages.

Tips for spotting a smishing message

Although the sender's name and number may appear legitimate in a smishing message, there are common warning signs to watch for, including:

- urgent claims about accounts being "locked" or "compromised"
- suspicious links using URL shorteners or slightly altered web addresses
- requests for sensitive information such as passwords, PIN (personal identification number)s, or SIN (social insurance number)s

These are all details that legitimate organizations would not request through text messages.


9:41
787878
Your NorthernSpruce Credit verification code is 542910.
Your NorthernSpruce Credit verification code is 781065.
Your NorthernSpruce Credit verification code is 684237.
NorthernSpruce Credit: Your account is locked. Please verify your details at https://northernspruce-credit.com
Text Message

Protect yourself from smishing

To protect yourself from smishing attacks, follow these recommended

▶ Long description - Figure 1: Example of a smishing message

mitigation strategies.

Do not click links

Do not click links received by SMS (short message service) message. If you receive an urgent message or a message with a suspicious or unusual link, pause before reacting. Scammers rely on impulsive reactions. Navigate to the organization's official online portal using your browser or official mobile app.

Verify independently

If a message appears in a legitimate message thread (for example, from your bank), call the number on the back of your debit or credit card to verify the request. Do not call the number provided in the text.

Report the spam

Forward the suspicious SMS (short message service) to 7726 (SPAM) or use the messaging applications spam reporting function. You can also report the spam to the Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre. This will notify the appropriate organizations to initiate an investigation and take appropriate actions.

Enable multi-factor authentication

Ensure MFA (multi-factor authentication) is enabled on your accounts to prevent unauthorized access even if credentials are stolen. Whenever possible, choose MFA (multi-factor authentication) options that do not rely

on SMS (short message service) like an authenticator app, or options that are phishing-resistant such as passkeys, or hardware tokens.

Disable 2G

If your phone allows it, turn off 2G in the settings. This can help prevent your phone from connecting to a false base station operated by a threat actor.

Stay updated

Keep your device's software current and enable SMS (short message service) spam protection.

Delete suspicious messages

If the suspicious sender is a new number, block it. Delete suspicious messages to avoid accidentally clicking the link.

Learn more

- Smishing: An introduction
- Don't take the bait: Recognize and avoid phishing attacks (ITSAP.00.101)
- Phishing: Don't get reeled in
- The 7 red flags of phishing
- Fact sheet: Phishing
- Three common types of phishing scams
- Using your mobile device securely (ITSAP.00.001)
- Reporting spam text messages to 7726

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